

Occupational Health Psychology

Understanding work stress and wellbeing through the major models

4 major models · tips — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Understanding work stress and wellbeing through the major models

Why does the same job exhaust one person and fulfill another? Occupational health psychology offers models to understand stress, engagement and burnout — and where to act.

This guide presents four major models and helps you apply them to your own situation.

Your intention

What weighs most in your work right now: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

Demand – Control – Support

For Karasek (then Theorell), stress ('job strain') arises from high psychological demand combined with low decision latitude (little control). Social support (colleagues, management) buffers this stress.

High demand + low control + low support = a high-risk situation.

Example

Swamped with tasks but with no room to maneuver, Sarah burned out. Gaining a little autonomy changed everything.

My job strain

Rate (low/high): your demand, your control, your support. Where's the imbalance?

Where to act

How could you gain a little control or support on a key task? _____

→ *High demand + low control = stress; support protects.*

Effort – Reward Balance

For Siegrist, stress comes from an imbalance between high effort and insufficient reward (pay, esteem, recognition, security, prospects). Giving a lot for little in return wears you down.

Personal overcommitment worsens this imbalance.

Example

All-in but never recognized or raised, Karim grew demotivated. Naming the imbalance helped him act (negotiate, reposition).

My balance

List your efforts · your rewards (pay, esteem, recognition, prospects). Balanced?

Rebalance

A reward to ask for/seek, or an effort to adjust: _____

→ *High effort for low reward = stress.*

Demands – Resources

The Job Demands-Resources model (Bakker & Demerouti) distinguishes demands (load, pressure, conflict) that drain, and resources (autonomy, support, meaning, feedback, development) that protect and feed engagement.

Increasing resources is often more effective than only reducing demands.

Example

Unable to lower her load, Léa cultivated her resources (meaning, mutual help, small wins) — and held on without burning out.

Demands vs resources

List 2 demands that drain you · 2 resources that carry you.

Cultivate a resource

A resource (autonomy, meaning, support) to develop this week: _____

→ *Resources protect as much as reducing demands.*

Burnout & the stress response

Burnout (Maslach) combines emotional exhaustion, cynicism/depersonalization and reduced accomplishment. It's a process, not a weakness. On stress, Selye describes a general adaptation syndrome, and Lazarus shows that how we appraise a situation modulates its load.

Spotting the signs early lets you act before exhaustion.

Example

Cynical and drained without knowing why, Marc recognized the signs of burnout — and consulted in time.

My signals

Do you notice signs (exhaustion, cynicism, reduced accomplishment)? Which?

My appraisal

A situation you could reappraise (threat → manageable challenge): _____

→ *Burnout is a process to spot early — not a weakness.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- Work stress often comes from imbalance: too many demands, too little control, resources or reward.
- Social support protects — cultivate it.
- Identify your resources (autonomy, meaning, support) and increase them, not only reduce load.
- Burnout isn't a weakness but a process to spot early.
- Your appraisal of a situation modulates its stress (threat vs challenge).
- Acting on the organization (not only the individual) matters a lot.

To fill in

My diagnosis

Demand/effort/load	Control/resource/reward

My plan

Resource to cultivate	Signal to watch

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Analyze my job strain (Karasek).

Week 2 — Assess effort/reward (Siegrist).

Week 3 — Cultivate my resources (JD-R).

Week 4 — Spot burnout signals & act.

Your plan in 3 lines

- My main imbalance:
- The resource I cultivate:
- The signal I watch:

TO CLOSE

Understanding the models means knowing where to act on your health at work.

Understanding the models means knowing where to act.

This guide is a psychoeducation and coaching tool — not therapy or medical advice. If stress becomes chronic or turns into burnout, consult a doctor or an (occupational) psychologist. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.